



Leader of the pack

Colonel Robin Olds paints a victory star on the McDonnell F-4 Phantom in which he shot down a MiG-21 on May 4, 1967. Olds led the USAF's 8th Tactical Fighter Wing, which downed 24 NVA planes in total.

Rescue and recovery

Airmen faced extreme risks on every mission. The possibility of rescue boosted morale. By 1966, the USAF had four Aerospace Rescue and Recovery Group squadrons in South Vietnam and one in Thailand, with numerous ground bases on constant alert and airborne orbits over Laos. The SAR task forces usually consisted of two HH-3 Jolly Green Giant helicopters, two A-1 Skyraider escorts, and an HC-130 control aircraft. Rescuing downed airmen was hazardous. Crewmen earned more than 9,000 medals for valor in 2,800 rescues.